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Communication and Language Learning コミュニケーションと言語学習

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Objectives

In second language acquisition, communication is both the purpose and the goal of language learning, and it significantly impacts it. On the communication, what resources do we use to convey our intentions in communication? In this talk, I will discuss my observations on communication in VR spaces.

第二言語習得において、コミュニケーションは、言語習得の目的(目標)そのものであると同時に、言語習得の成否に大きな作用をもたらす。人はコミュニケーションにおいて、どのような「資源」を使って意思を伝達しあい、そして心を通わせるか。VR空間でのコミュニケーションの様相を観察して見えてきたことを述べる。

Key words

Metaverse, VR(virtual reality), communication, [cross-cultural understanding](#), second language acquisition

Contents

1. SLA and Language Learning Context

第二言語習得と環境

2. Video conferencing for cross-cultural understanding

異文化理解のためのビデオ会議ディスカッション

3. Aspects of Various Formats of Online of Discussion

異なる遠隔環境におけるコミュニケーションの様相の比較

4. Reasons for comfortability through VR formats

VR空間におけるコミュニケーションの特徴

5. Learning Context and Second Language Acquisition

コミュニケーション環境と言語習得

References 参考文献

1. SLA and Language Learning Context

JSL and JFL

JSL (Japanese as a Second Language)

Number of Learners in Japan: **263,170**

Source: 文部科学省MEXT「令和5年日本語教育実態調査」

Learners are studying the L2 in an environment in which the language of study is also the language of the larger society.

e.g. Learning Japanese in Japan

JFL (Japanese as a Foreign Language)

Number of Learners abroad: **3,794,714**

Source: The Japan Foundation "Survey on Japanese-Language Education Abroad 2021"

The target language is not spoken in the wider society, and learners are often fairly homogenous in terms of L1.

e.g. Learning Japanese at the language class in home country

Social context obviously plays a large role in the amount and type of input that learners receive, as well as the opportunities they have to produce the L2.

1. SLA and Language Learning Context

How language are learned...

- Interaction Approach (→ Input-Interaction-Output)
Interaction Hypnosis:
language learning is enhanced through interaction, as it provides opportunities for learners to receive feedback and modify their output, facilitating comprehension and acquisition (Long 1980) .
- After **Social Turn**, various social factors involved in the L2 learning process are considered in second language acquisition.

1. SLA and Language Learning Context

JSL and JFL

(Sometimes) JFL Learners feel:

Lack of the opportunity to use target language in the meaningful context.
Difficult to maintain the motivation for learning target language.



Create a “meaningful context” to interact in L2 in distance learning space.



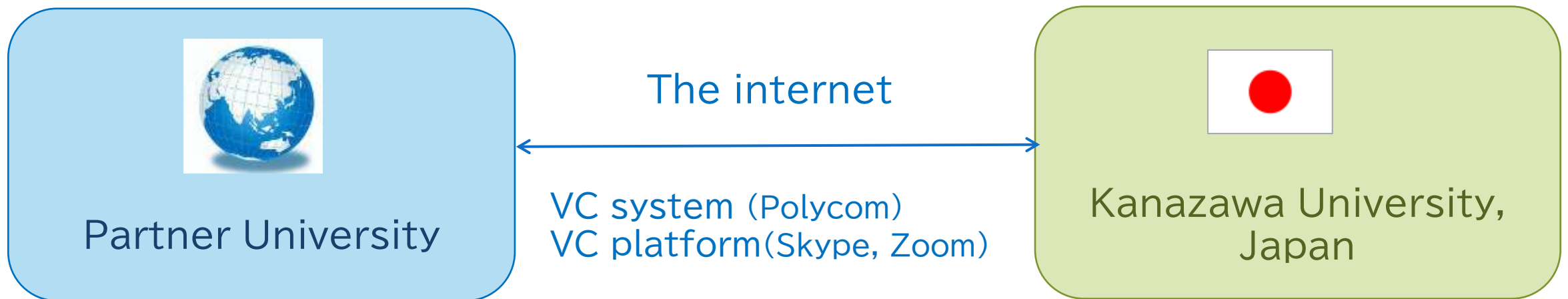
Video conferencing for cross-cultural understanding (“VC discussion”)

2. Video conferencing for cross-cultural understanding

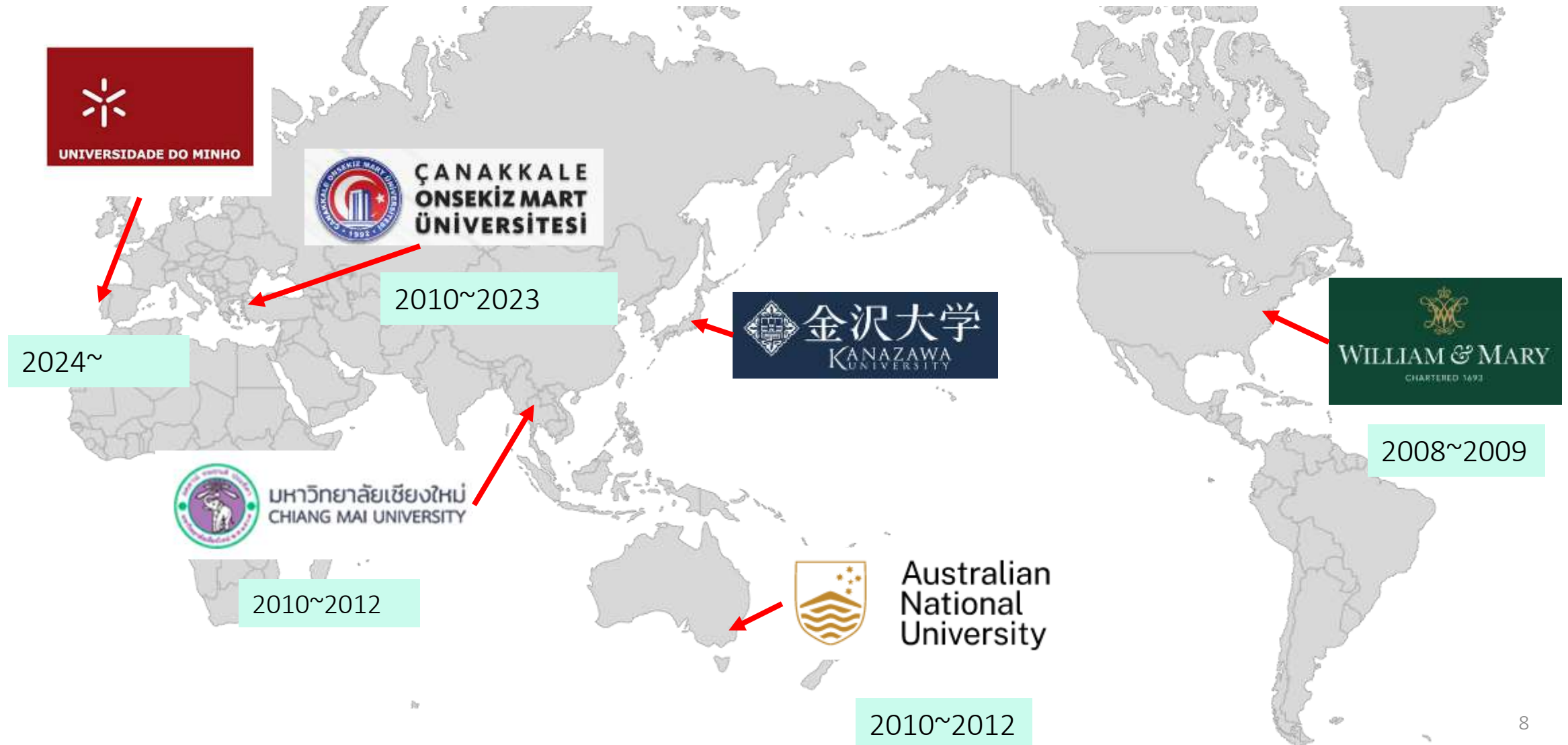
Objectives

- Educational practice between Kanazawa University and overseas partner universities which aims to deepen students' understanding about each/own society and culture.
- Students exchange (interact) their thoughts and opinions about various aspects of the society (social problems in each country, global issues) in Japanese language.
- JFL learners get the opportunity to communicate in Japanese in the meaningful context.

≡ COIL (Collaborative Online International Learning)



2. Video conferencing for cross-cultural understanding History of the Educational Practice



2. Video conferencing for cross-cultural understanding

The Significance of VC Discussions

- Real-time exchange of opinions with students at overseas

It was good to hear the opinions and thoughts of people of the same generation, such as university students, which you don't usually hear on the internet or in the mass media. (Japanese student)

- Able to accept and think about various things from various non-verbal information obtained through images and sounds.

I can see the other person's facial expressions as I interact. (Japanese student)

I thought they might cover up their appearance because of their strong religious beliefs, but I was surprised to see that they dressed exactly like us.... (Japanese student)

- Audio and video information is also useful for language learning.

Listening to Japanese students, I also learned about correct pronunciation and intonation. (Overseas student)

2. Video conferencing for cross-cultural understanding

Forms of VC discussion

During the Covid-19 pandemic, 2020, both universities entered distance learning, so students couldn't meet up at the classroom and had to access from each place via zoom.

With the evolution of technology, we can communicate not only in real life, but also in virtual reality.



Are there any differences between these new forms of communication?

To examine aspects of various formats of online of discussion for cross-cultural understanding and language learning. (Fukagawa et al. 2024)

3. Aspects of Various Formats of Online of Discussion Research Design & Methods

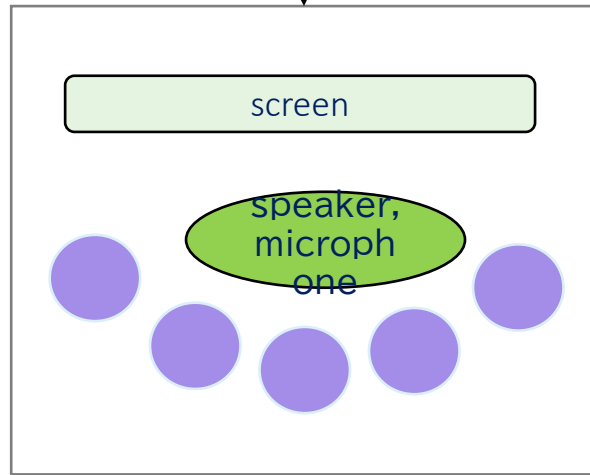
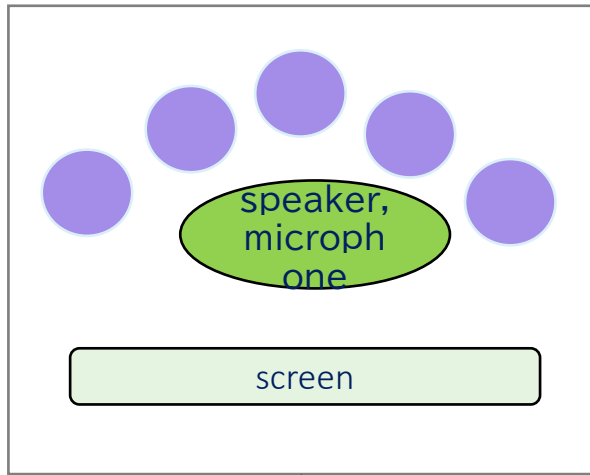
Settings - Forms of VC discussion

Discussions were conducted through three formats in order to investigate whether different forms of video conferencing influence the structure of communication:

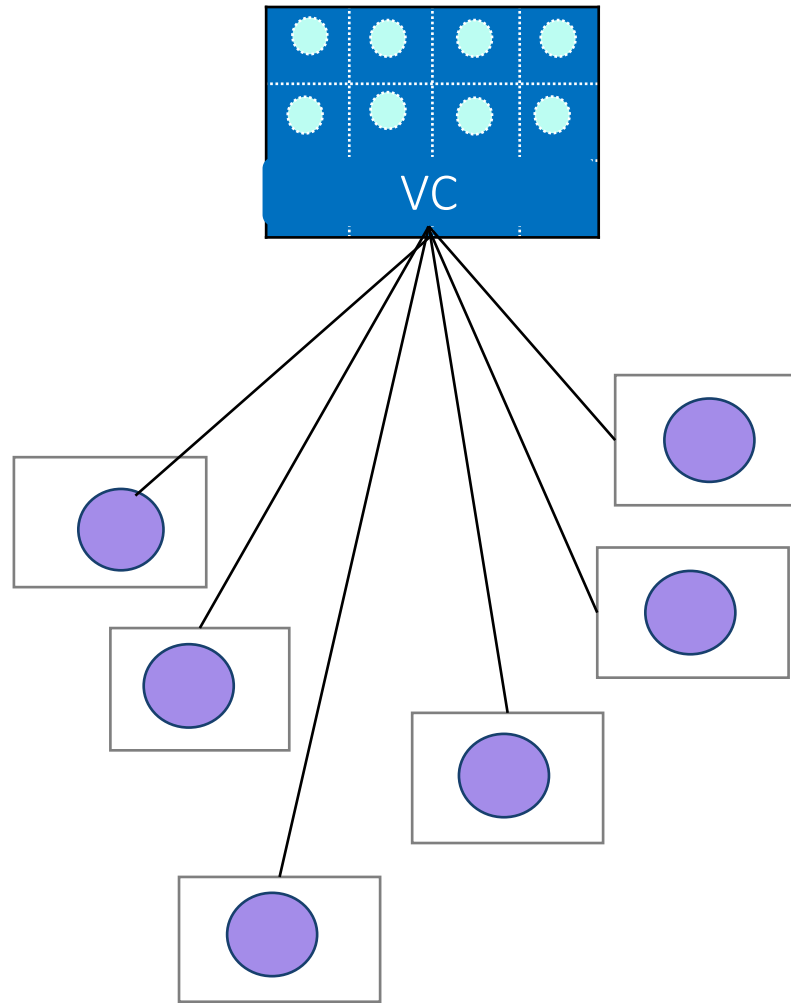
VC-intergroup connection: Students gathered in classrooms at each university and connected through Skype or Zoom

VC-individual connection: Students connected from places of their individual convenience via Zoom

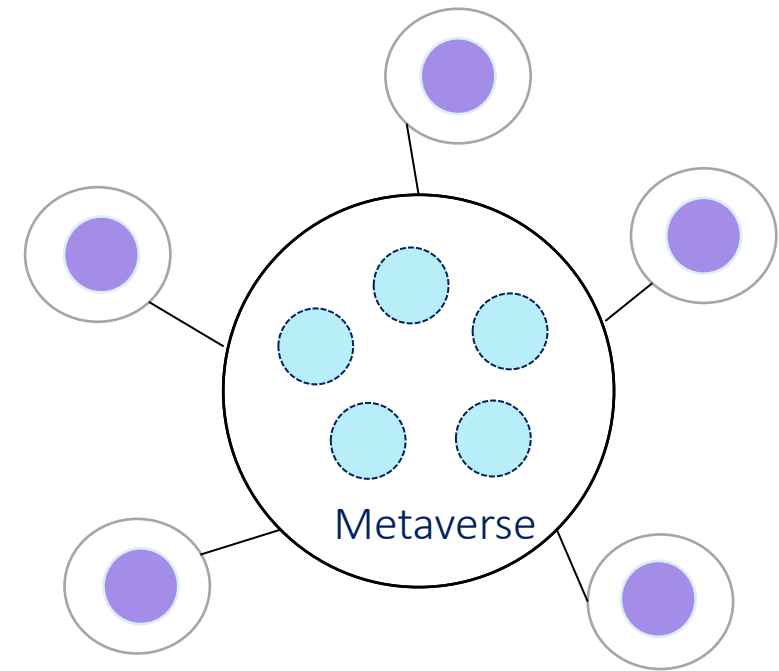
Virtual reality (VR) metaverse platform: Students connected from places of their individual convenience through Horizon Workrooms



intergroup connection



individual connection



VR

Virtual reality (VR)



3. Aspects of Various Formats of Online of Discussion Results

Aspect of turn-taking and pauses (Table 1)

Table 1 Frequency of turn-taking and duration of pauses for each discussion format

Discussion Format	Frequency of turn-taking (average)	Average pause between turn-taking (sec.)	Maximum pause between turn-taking (sec.)
VC-intergroup	108.33	2.16	8.0
VC-individual	66.33	2.42	9.0
VR	127.00	1.29	4.1

3. Aspects of Various Formats of Online of Discussion Results

Aspect of non-verbal communication

Based on observation by presenters, comments in questionnaires, and interviews by participants

Aspect	VC individual	VC intergroup	VR
Recognition of the current speaker's face	Sometimes difficult	More easily recognized	Very easy
Smoothness of turn-taking (overlapping, interruption)	Observed more frequently	Observed sometimes	Observed at times
Atmosphere (e.g., facial expression and laughter)	Did not observe frequently	Displayed more laughter than VC-individual	Displayed more laughter than VC-intergroup
Gesturing	Hardly observed	Did not observe frequently	observed sometimes
Movement (e.g. nodding)	Did not observe frequently	Observed sometimes.	observed frequently

4. Reasons for comfortability through VR formats

Non-verbal behaviors

- Body(Face) orientation
- Eye contact, blink
- Nodding
- back-channeling
- Gesturing
- Physical contact

4. Reasons for comfortability through VR formats

Psychological factors

- immersive experience in Metaverse
 - ... Sense of unity and intimacy

Participants' comments

- *"As the sessions went on, I felt more and more familiar with them."* ...feeling of affinity

- Communication through avatar
 - Without exposing yourself ... Reduction of second language anxiety
 - Easy to change your appearance ... Transcendence of race, identity

5. Learning Context and Second Language Acquisition

Possibility of VR as another option of format for Learning Context

Merit

- Flexibility and efficiency of time and place
... Solution to the problems of distance and transportation cost
- Easy Communication
... Encourage interaction
- Immersiveness of VR
... Sense of unity and intimacy

Problem

Physical and technical issues:

Restrictions and cost for an equipment such as VR headsets

Physical burdens of wearing VR headsets

5. Learning Context and Second Language Acquisition

Technology-enhanced language learning contexts

- Changes in technology surrounding language learning (e.g. Metaverse, GenAI)
- CALL (Computer-Assisted Language Learning)
- CMC (Computer-mediated communication)
 - Potential of online gaming environments for L2 learners
- Computer-mediated social interaction

Technology-enhanced language learning contexts have created new opportunities for L2 learning and seem to generally promote L2 development.

(Loewen 2020)

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